

Editorial

Bread And Butter... And Broadband

WE NEED FOOD. We need power. We need water. But if the year 2007 has been declared by the government as the “Year of Broadband,” we demand an uninterrupted supply of broadband as well.

The mayor of San Francisco once said Wi-Fi was a fundamental human right. I’m going along those lines—not quite, but close.

When our former IT minister Dayanidhi Maran led the DoT (Dept of Telecom) and conceived of an ambitious plan to offer free broadband through BSNL and MTNL at 2 Mbps by 2009, it sent newswires across the nation buzzing. Consumers like myself blessed him and sent him sincere, heartfelt thanks before going to bed. A fortnight later, though, the minister had to quit. The best laid plans of mice and men...

The figure for broadband connections in India stands close to 3 million, while the government plans to take it up to 9 million by year’s end. How? Your guess could well be better than mine. I’m clueless.

Post the exit of Maran (I must admit he has done much, much more than his earlier counterparts), another nail-in-the-coffin for broadband dreams came from the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI), when it recommended an entry fee for issuing new ISP licences, and a reduction in the foreign direct investment (FDI) limit to 74 per cent from the existing 100 per cent.

In its recommendations, the TRAI said the current free entry of ISPs should be terminated, and that there should be an entry fee of Rs 20 lakh for national-level ISPs and Rs 10 lakh for state-level ISPs.

The TRAI has also recommended charging an annual licence fee of six per cent of gross revenue to all operational ISPs. If these recommendations are implemented, broadband access is slated to become more expensive, leave alone becoming free. So how does this pare up with the earlier plans? Or does the plan now change because of the musical chairs being played out amongst the figureheads at our IT ministry?

Will the incumbent IT minister announce another populist scheme, giving us another dream—only to pull it down later?

I’d always thought the principal role of the TRAI was to uphold the consumer’s interest and protect him from monopolistic pricing and cartelisation. Now, it not only strikes down at the hopes of new



Deepak Ajwani Executive Editor

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ISP aspirants, it also eliminates competition.

In any case, is free broadband sustainable? What we’ve seen is, when you make something free, it runs into the problems of low-quality service and upgrade costs. How concerned have you been while using public utilities and transport? Ever cared enough to wipe your seat on a bus, or clean a public toilet? Free broadband also means we consumers will use as it much as possible. Every house will set pirated movies to download. The pipes will choke. This will again lead to abysmal quality of service.

Charging a fixed fee no matter how much bandwidth a customer uses is as good as giving the service away for free. So if anyone’s listening, charge us—but give us consistent and quality broadband, please!

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A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Deepak Ajwani'.